



SUMITA DAWRA

59, Secretary, Ministry of Labour and Employment

MAKING IT WORK

Labour Secretary Sumita Dawra and her team are pulling out all stops to ensure the smooth roll-out of the ELI schemes

BY SURABHI

SUMITA DAWRA DREAMT of becoming a civil servant from her childhood. So, when she made the cut, she believed that she had achieved her goal. “But that’s when my father told me that my work has just started because I have to now establish my reputation as a civil servant,” says the Secretary of the Ministry of

Labour and Employment.

A career bureaucrat, Dawra is a 1991 batch Indian Administrative Services officer of the Andhra Pradesh cadre. She has vast experience, having worked both in states as well as at the Centre in various assignments, ranging from rural development in Andhra Pradesh to a stint in the Union finance ministry and as head of the Economic Wing in the Indian Mission in Beijing. She also served as Special Secretary in the Logistics division of DPIIT, and oversaw the implementation of the flagship PM GatiShakti National Master Plan.

In late February, she was appointed Officer on Special Duty at the labour ministry, and took charge as Secretary on March 1. “There is a huge spectrum of challenges and opportunities to deliver results. One doesn’t get such opportunities in other jobs,” she says.

The challenges and opportunities are large indeed. For, she spearheads a number of key schemes, including the ambitious employment-linked incentive

(ELI) schemes, launched with much fanfare by the Union government, that aim to provide regular wage employment to 29 million job seekers and tackle India’s pressing employment concerns. That’s the reason she has debuted on the *BT* Most Powerful Women in Business list this year.

“There is a lot of meaningful work here, and you can impact the lives of millions of people by working together with states, employers, and employees to go

WHAT WOULD YOU ADVISE YOUR YOUNGER SELF?

I have devoted my life to my work, spend more time with family

WHAT IS YOUR MANTRA FOR NAVIGATING CHALLENGES?

Identify the priority task that will bring maximum benefit, put in timelines and ensure the team is working and lead from the front

ahead in the best possible manner for labour welfare, employment, and investment generation,” she underlines.

But that’s not all. While the ELI is a key focus area for her, other priorities include labour reforms as well as the long-pending Labour Codes along with the states and lower compliance to enable more ease of doing business.

“My guiding principle has been to deliver the maximum good I can within my mandate,” she highlights. **BT**

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